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PUNJAB

PUNCHLINE IN PUNJAB

Comedian versus comedian? A touch of tragedy may always lie beneath the hurly-burly of Punjab's politics, but if the buzz is to be believed, Amritsar East constituency is in line to see plenty of speech balloons from two contestants associated more with laughter emojis. **Bhagwant Mann**, comedian-turned-MP and AAP's Punjab convenor, is bracing himself to take on the cricketer-turned-entertainer-turned-neta, Punjab Congress chief **Navjot Singh Sidhu**. No laughing matter this, of course. Both are chief minister aspirants in their current parties. After securing anticipatory bail in a drugs case, Akali Dal heavyweight Bikramjit Majithia is also gearing up to challenge Sidhu in Amritsar East. What may play spoiler in this prize fight is the prospect of another one: a strong lobby in the Congress wants Sidhu to shift back to his hometown Patiala and challenge bete noire Capt. Amarinder Singh. Meanwhile, the BJP too hopes to have a party-hopper in the fray from Amritsar East: it's talking to a national leader from the Congress to switch over and do the honours. A Jat Sikh too, the community it badly wants to mollify. Back in the late '90s, Akali Dal stalwarts Surjit Singh Barnala and Gurcharan Singh Tohra had been uncomfortable with party chief Parkash Singh Badal joining hands with the saffronistas. Over two decades later, the BJP is more dyed-in-the-wool Hindutva if anything, but Punjab will be treated to the spectacle of the grandchildren of Barnala and Tohra contesting for the party. Let's see who lands the best punchlines.

–Anilesh S. Mahajan

MANIPUR

Where's the Party?

Diehard Congress voters in Manipur must be a confused lot. Ever since the BJP turned the 2017 mandate on its head, conjuring up a salad bowl government against implausible odds, the Congress tally in the assembly has been steadily dwindling. From 28, it's now down to 13. Chaltonlien Amo, MLA from Tipaimukh, has become the latest to hop on to the gravy train. A day after the EC announced poll dates, Amo joined over a dozen of his former peers in the ruling BJP—a list that includes even Govindas Konthoujam, a former PCC chief. Rajkumar Imo Singh, former Congress MLA and son-in-law of Chief Minister N. Biren Singh, is the mastermind behind most of the defections. In fact, Biren Singh himself had made that long jump in 2016, months before the last assembly polls. After winning only 21 seats, the BJP had stitched together a coalition regime with the support of four National People's Party (NPP) MLAs, four Naga People's Front (NPF) members, the lone Trinamool Congress MLA, and an Independent member.

–Kaushik Deka

